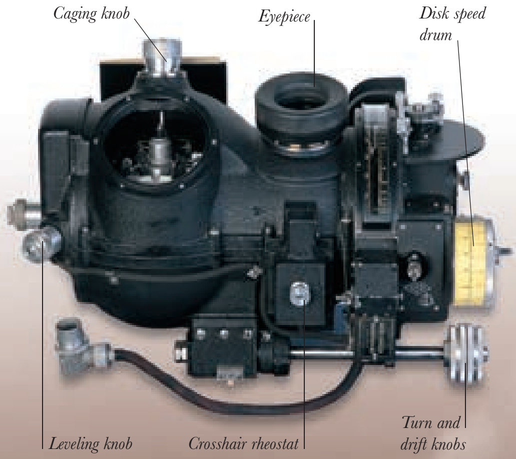

NORDEN BOMBSIGHT
The bombardier fed the Norden bombsight with data on airspeed, wind direction, and other relevant factors, and waited for two crosshairs to fix on the target several miles ahead. The Norden then told him how to fly the aircraft and when to drop the bombs.

answer to *Schräge Musik*, but they did develop a whole range of countermeasures to jam or confuse German radars and radios, as well as equipping bombers with short-range radars to detect incoming fighters.

The effectiveness of German air defenses could be measured by Bomber Command losses. Between August 1943 and March 1944, a period when the main target of the RAF night offensive was Berlin, on average about one in 20 bombers was lost on each raid. And there was, from the RAF's point of view, no sign of improvement. Right at the end of March 1944, in one particularly disastrous raid on the city of Nuremberg, 95 out of 795 bombers sent out did not return.

American involvement

During 1942, the USAAF joined in the European bombing campaign. Despite the discouraging British experience earlier in the war, American commanders were convinced that their unescorted bombers could penetrate the German defenses in daylight, carrying out precision raids on key strategic targets. In theory, the Boeing B-17s and Consolidated B-24s would fly too high to be hit by flak and the interlocking gunfire of their mass formations would face off enemy fighters. Attacking targets in Germany, the bombers would "shoot their way in and shoot their way out again."

The air and ground crews of the US Eighth Air Force arriving at airbases in the east of England had more to get used to than just tea and warm beer. The reality of war in Europe proved radically different from training in Texas or Arizona. First, there was the weather. One airman said of Britain: "I love that country. The people are fighters and made of the right stuff, but the climate was not my cup of tea and hell to fly in." The advantage of day bombing over night bombing resided in visibility. But in Europe cloud cover was so common and so unpredictable that this advantage often did not exist.

The key to USAAF expectations of hitting precision targets was the Norden bombsight (see left), a sophisticated proto-computer that could "drop a bomb in a pickle barrel." These